

Roasted pepper and chanterelle mushroom pasta

This is a colorful dish with a deep complexity of character and flavor. You can make this dish all year, of course, but there is something special about the fall, when chanterelle mushrooms and hot chiles are abundant and at their peak. Chanterelle mushrooms are **extra-special**, so I encourage you to seek them out. You can use other mushrooms or a combination of fresh and dried as well. As for the hot peppers, look for a variety from sweet to mild to hot; combining them works beautifully here.

1 head of garlic

2 tablespoons extra virgin olive oil

1 pound penne [500g]

4 fresh mild to hot peppers (red and/or yellow sweet bell, cayenne, green and/or red jalapeño, güero or banana, and the like)

3 large tomatoes

1 large yellow onion, thinly sliced

½ pound fresh chanterelle mushrooms, sliced [250g]

Salt and freshly ground pepper

Splash of balsamic vinegar

1. Preheat the oven to 325°F [160°C]. **Separate** the head of garlic into individual cloves. Skin them and cut off the hard bits on the ends. (It's okay if the cloves get crushed while you peel the skin off them.) Toss with 1½ teaspoons of the olive oil to coat lightly. Roast in a small covered baking dish for 30 to 40 minutes, or until lightly browned and very soft. Toss them once or twice while they are cooking.
2. Bring at least 4 quarts [4L] salted water to a vigorous boil. **Add** the pasta and stir immediately and often until the water returns to a boil. Cook until the pasta is al dente (slightly resistant to the bite), then drain it quickly in a ready colander. Shake out the water completely. Run under cold water until the heat is completely dissipated and the pasta is cold to the touch. Toss with 1½ teaspoons of the olive oil and set aside.

3. While the pasta and garlic are cooking, prepare the peppers. Make sure the kitchen is well ventilated before heating a cast-iron skillet to medium-hot. **Slice** the peppers in half, remove the seeds and ribs, and flatten them out. Cut the larger bell peppers into quarters. Cook the peppers, slim side down, until moderately blackened and soft. While cooking, add a few drops of olive oil and turn several times with tongs. Set aside. When cool, coarsely chop by hand or in a food processor.
4. When the garlic is done, remove it to a plate and raise the oven temperature to broil. Set a rack 5 to 6 inches [13 to 15cm] from the heat. Lay out the tomatoes on a baking sheet and **broil**, turning them with tongs until they are lightly blackened and softened, with skins split and peeling off, 7 to 10 minutes. As soon as they are cool enough to handle, peel off the skins, coarsely chop the tomatoes, and set them aside in a bowl along with their juices.
5. In the skillet, **cook** the onion in the remaining 1 tablespoon of the oil over medium heat until softened and lightly browned, about 5 minutes. Add the roasted garlic and cook for another minute, lightly mashing down a few of the garlic cloves. Add the mushrooms and cook until tender, about 5 minutes. Add the tomatoes with their juices. Cook over medium-low heat, stirring occasionally, until the tomatoes and garlic break down and the sauce begins to thicken.
6. Add 3 to 4 tablespoons of the roasted peppers and the cooked pasta to the tomato sauce. **Toss** until the pasta is heated through and completely coated with sauce. Season with salt and pepper to taste. Splash with vinegar and serve immediately. Toss with additional extra virgin olive oil, if desired.

SERVES 4 TO 6

note The recipe calls for a relatively small amount of mixed peppers. However, I highly recommend that you roast a whole batch of them. Freeze some after roasting so you'll have them in the off-season.